Well, here was my point. The committees, no doubt, had their utility, but they also smacked of bureaucracy. Going by our experience with the development of much smaller engines and systems, committees, even while ensuring quality of the work, have delayed projects. Vikas is a project on fast-track, something that has to be completed on a war-footing, so that PSLV lifts off by at least 1992. India could not wait to launch its first big rocket using a liquid propulsion engine.

Part two of my argument also did not go down well with some colleagues, but it stems from a level of ultimate confidence. I, as the head of the team that developed the Vikas-Viking engine in collaboration with the French, know better than anyone the systems and sub-systems here. I know the margins of error and how much of it would be tolerable for a successful project. Yes, you can suspect that this being my project I might manipulate some of the readings and waive off the margins. Let me tell anyone who has such suspicion that this is my baby, I will do nothing to make it fail. Well, if it fails, haul me up, hunt me down. But for now, please let me get on with the work.

There were protests, but Satish Dhawan again came as my saviour. ‘The project has its urgency,’ he said. ‘And let Nambi be accountable for this.’

I was not done with it. I wanted this arrangement of a single person heading both the committees as an exception, not a rule. I told Dhawan that this should be considered as a special case since we were in development stage which cannot be delayed. Once the rocket flies and we get into the production mode, the non-conformance committee and the waiver committee should be headed by different people. Dhawan frowned, then smiled.